The Jewish Agency in Palestine officially accepted the plan despite the exclusion of Jerusalem from the Jewish state: the Jews in Palestine were pleased that they now had international support for the idea of a Jewish state. But not all of them were happy with the plan: not only was Jerusalem excluded from the Jewish state but many Jewish settlements were to be included in the Arab state. Menachem Begin, leader of Irgun, announced:

> The partition of the homeland is illegal. It will never be recognised. It will not bind the Jewish people. Jerusalem was and will forever be our capital. **Eretz Israel** will be restored to the people of Israel. All of it. And for ever.

David Ben-Gurion said:

> Tens of thousands of our youth are prepared to lay down their lives for the sake of Jerusalem. It is within the boundaries of the state of Israel just as Tel Aviv is.

Key terms

Eretz Israel
The Land of Israel, as in the Bible. In effect, this meant the whole of Palestine, not just the area allocated to the Jewish state by the UN.

Arab Higher Committee
A committee of Palestinian Arab leaders.

The **Arab Higher Committee**, representing the Palestinian Arabs, rejected the UN partition plan, especially as the Jews were to be given the larger area. The Arabs did not wish to give up any of their land. They felt that the Western powers should find a home for the Jews elsewhere.

Key question
Why was there a civil war in Palestine?

Civil war in Palestine, November 1947 to May 1948

Key dates

Start of civil war in Palestine: November 1947

British announcement that they would leave Palestine: December 1947

A few days after the UN voted for partition, the Arab Higher Committee proclaimed a three-day strike which led to outbreaks of violence against Jewish civilians. However, the Jewish Agency and its forces were ready to respond. They had always known that the Arabs would resist the establishment of a Jewish state in Palestine. In December, when the British announced that they would leave Palestine in May 1948, the fighting between Arabs and Jews intensified. At first, the Jewish forces acted defensively: they sought to hold on to and defend the land they had been allocated by the UN. However, they soon also went on the offensive and fought to gain control of Jewish settlements in the land allocated to the Arabs and of the roads leading to them.

In 1948, soldiers from Syria and Iraq began to cross into Palestine to help the Arabs. Again, this was no surprise to the Jewish leaders. They fully expected neighbouring Arab states to invade Palestine when the British left and the new Jewish state came into existence. So they resolved to secure control over Jewish territory. In March the Haganah came up with Plan D, the aim of which was to:

- take over any installations evacuated by the British, especially military bases
- expel as many Palestinians as possible from the future Jewish state.